

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Samkhya (Sāṃkhya) - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Samkhya (Sāṃkhya)

English-first concept spine • Sanskrit/Pali IAST follows in parentheses

- 1 primordial material nature (prakṛti)
- 2 conscious witness (puruṣa)
- 3 earliest extant systematic classical text
- 4 threefold suffering
- 5 operation due to causal power (śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca)
- 6 pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda)

Read the complete Markdown/PDF for arguments, objections, PYQs and model answers.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Samkhya (Sāṃkhya) - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed. across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

Questions 1-40 diagnose core doctrine and exam traps. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed.

1. Which set exhausts the means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) admitted by classical Sāṃkhya?

A. Perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna) and āptavacana/verbal testimony (śabda) B. Perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna), comparison (upamāna) and verbal testimony (śabda) C. Six means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) including non-cognition (anupalabdhi) D. Perception (pratyakṣa) alone

Answer: A. Perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna) and āptavacana/verbal testimony (śabda)

Explanation: Sāṃkhya accepts perception, inference and trustworthy testimony; other proposed instruments are reduced to these three.

2. Which inference chiefly carries Sāṃkhya from manifest experience to imperceptible Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and Conscious witness (puruṣa)?

A. Śeṣavat B. Sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa C. Kevalavyatireki D. Pūrvavat

Answer: B. Sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa

Explanation: Sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa works through general correlation where the inferred entity is not an ordinary sense-object.

3. Which statement correctly pairs Sāṃkhya's two ultimate realities?

A. Many conscious Prakṛtis and one Conscious witness (puruṣa) B. One Brahman appearing as both C. One unconscious Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and many inactive conscious Conscious witness (puruṣas) D. One conscious Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and many active Conscious witness (puruṣas)

Answer: C. One unconscious Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and many inactive conscious Conscious witness (puruṣas)

Explanation: Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is the single unconscious material root; Conscious witness (puruṣas) are many changeless witnesses, never productive agents.

4. Why does imperceptibility not by itself refute mūla-Prakṛti?

A. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is a gross element B. Conscious witness (puruṣa) perceives it as an object C. Scripture makes inference unnecessary D. Non-perception can result from subtlety, not non-existence

Answer: D. Non-perception can result from subtlety, not non-existence

Explanation: Root Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is atīndriya especially through sauṣṭmya, so it must be inferred.

5. Which proof most directly supports the existence of one Primordial material nature (prakṛti)?

A. Avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya B. Asadakaraṇāt C. Bhoktr-bhāvāt D. Kaivalyārthaṃ pravṛtteḥ

Answer: A. Avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya

Explanation: A diversified yet interconnected cosmos points to one undivided unmanifest source.

6. In bhedānām parimāṇāt, finite effects indicate:

A. That atoms are conscious B. A subtler material ground from which limitation emerges C. A creator Conscious witness (puruṣa) D. That effects are illusory

Answer: B. A subtler material ground from which limitation emerges

Explanation: The argument moves from delimited effects to a fundamental material source, not to a creator God.

7. Which statement best captures the status of the qualities (guṇas)?

A. Qualities inhering in Conscious witness (puruṣa) B. Moral labels applied after evolution C. Inseparable constitutive strands of Primordial material nature (prakṛti) D. Three independent substances

Answer: C. Inseparable constitutive strands of Primordial material nature (prakṛti)

Explanation: Sattva, rajas and tamas constitute Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and occur together in every evolute in varying proportions.

8. What is sāmyāvasthā?

A. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) appropriating cognition B. Liberation of all Conscious witness (puruṣas) C. Rajas dominating both branches D. Equilibrium of sattva, rajas and tamas in unmanifest Primordial material nature (prakṛti)

Answer: D. Equilibrium of sattva, rajas and tamas in unmanifest Primordial material nature (prakṛti)

Explanation: Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is unmanifest nature (avyakta) in equilibrium; manifestation begins with disequilibrium, not divine creation.

9. Sarūpa-pariṇāma denotes:

A. Homogeneous change of each constituent quality (guṇa) compatible with equilibrium B. Destruction of the qualities (guṇas) C. New production from prior absence D. Apparent transformation of Brahman

Answer: A. Homogeneous change of each constituent quality (guṇa) compatible with equilibrium

Explanation: It is same-form modification within equilibrium, allowing dynamism without differentiated evolutes.

10. Virūpa-pariṇāma begins when:

A. All karmic traces end B. Constituent quality (guṇa) equilibrium is disturbed and unequal predominance develops C. Cosmic intellect (mahat) becomes conscious D. Conscious witness (puruṣa) chooses to create

Answer: B. Constituent quality (guṇa) equilibrium is disturbed and unequal predominance develops

Explanation: Heterogeneous modification generates diversity. Conscious witness (puruṣa) occasions but does not agentively perform it.

11. Which is the first evolute of Primordial material nature (prakṛti)?

A. Ākāśa B. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) C. Cosmic intellect (mahat)/determinative intellect (buddhi) D. Sensory mind (manas)

Answer: C. Cosmic intellect (mahat)/determinative intellect (buddhi)

Explanation: Cosmic intellect (mahat), psychologically called determinative intellect (buddhi), is first; ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) follows.

12. Which statement about rājasa ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) is correct?

A. It is Conscious witness (puruṣa) B. It directly produces gross elements C. It produces a third tattva-set D. It energises both sāttvika and tāmasa lines

Answer: D. It energises both sāttvika and tāmasa lines

Explanation: Rajas supplies activity; it does not create a separate set of principles (tattvas).

13. What is determinative intellect (buddhi)'s distinctive function?

A. Adhyavasāya-determinate ascertainment and judgement B. Gross action C. Pure witnessing D. Coordination only

Answer: A. Adhyavasāya-determinate ascertainment and judgement

Explanation: Determinative intellect (buddhi) determines; sensory mind (manas) coordinates; ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) appropriates. Determinative intellect (buddhi) remains material.

14. Cosmic intellect (mahat) and determinative intellect (buddhi) are best understood as:

A. Two names of ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) B. One constitutive principle (tattva) viewed cosmically and psychologically C. Two halves of Conscious witness (puruṣa) D. Two successive evolutes

Answer: B. One constitutive principle (tattva) viewed cosmically and psychologically

Explanation: Cosmic intellect (mahat) is the cosmic and determinative intellect (buddhi) the psychological designation of the same first evolute.

15. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) is principally:

A. Pure consciousness B. The final gross element C. The I-maker appropriating functions as “I” and “mine” D. Reliable testimony

Answer: C. The I-maker appropriating functions as “I” and “mine”

Explanation: Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) individuates and appropriates reflected cognition and action; it is not Conscious witness (puruṣa).

16. Which is the exact tāmasa sequence?

A. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) -> faculties -> subtle element (tanmātras) B. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) -> sensory mind (manas) -> gross elements C. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) -> determinative intellect (buddhi) -> Conscious witness (puruṣa) D. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) -> five subtle element (tanmātras) -> five gross element (mahābhūtas)

Answer: D. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) -> five subtle element (tanmātras) -> five gross element (mahābhūtas)

Explanation: The tāmasa aspect yields subtle elements and then gross elements; faculties arise from the sāttvika aspect.

17. How many Prakṛti-side principles (tattvas) are counted before adding Conscious witness (puruṣa)?

A. Twenty-four B. Twenty-five C. Twenty-six D. Twenty-three

Answer: A. Twenty-four

Explanation: Primordial material nature (prakṛti) plus twenty-three evolutes make twenty-four; Conscious witness (puruṣa) is twenty-fifth and not an evolute.

18. Saṅghāta-parārthatvāt argues that:

A. Every aggregate is conscious B. Psychophysical aggregates function for a conscious beneficiary distinct from them C. Liberation proves Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is many D. Only scripture establishes Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Answer: B. Psychophysical aggregates function for a conscious beneficiary distinct from them

Explanation: Body, senses and mind are instrumental complexes; Sāṃkhya infers a conscious beneficiary.

19. Which proof infers Conscious witness (puruṣa) because pleasure, pain and delusion require an experiencer?

A. Trigunādi-viparyayāt B. Samanvayāt C. Bhokṣṭṛ-bhāvāt D. Adhiṣṭhānāt

Answer: C. Bhokṣṭṛ-bhāvāt

Explanation: Bhokṣṭṛ-bhāvāt argues from experienced states to a subject distinct from those objectifiable states.

20. What is the strongest measured verdict on the five proofs for Conscious witness (puruṣa)?

A. They prove only Primordial material nature (prakṛti) B. Each proves many Conscious witness (puruṣas) deductively C. They prove an active creator D. Cumulatively they support a subject-pole more strongly than many eternal inactive Conscious witness (puruṣas)

Answer: D. Cumulatively they support a subject-pole more strongly than many eternal inactive Conscious witness (puruṣas)

Explanation: The arguments have phenomenological force, but further premises are needed for eternity, inactivity and plurality.

21. Why does Sāṃkhya posit many Conscious witness (puruṣas)?

A. Distinct births, capacities, experiences and non-simultaneous liberation B. The Veda denies a witness C. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is plural D. Each body manufactures consciousness

Answer: A. Distinct births, capacities, experiences and non-simultaneous liberation

Explanation: Plurality safeguards non-transferable experience, action and moral consequence (karma) and liberation, though individuation remains disputed.

22. Advaita's central objection to Conscious witness (puruṣa) plurality is that:

A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) is material B. Differences belong to upādhis; pure consciousness lacks an individuating feature C. Plurality abolishes action and moral consequence (karma) D. All selves must create

Answer: B. Differences belong to upādhis; pure consciousness lacks an individuating feature

Explanation: Advaita claims Sāṃkhya proves many mental streams, not many pure consciousnesses.

23. Individual self (jīva) in Sāṃkhya is:

A. The single cosmic Primordial material nature (prakṛti) B. The gross body alone C. Conscious witness (puruṣa) empirically conditioned through determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) and subtle body D. A twenty-sixth constitutive principle (tattva)

Answer: C. Conscious witness (puruṣa) empirically conditioned through determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) and subtle body

Explanation: Individual self (jīva) is the embodied empirical subject generated by association and identification, not another principle.

24. Which statement avoids turning Conscious witness (puruṣa) into an agent?

A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) intentionally starts evolution B. Conscious witness (puruṣa) judges mentally C. Conscious witness (puruṣa) transforms into determinative intellect (buddhi) D. Agency belongs to Primordial material nature (prakṛti)'s evolutes while Conscious witness (puruṣa) witnesses

Answer: D. Agency belongs to Primordial material nature (prakṛti)'s evolutes while Conscious witness (puruṣa) witnesses

Explanation: All activity belongs to the guṇic apparatus; productive agency attributed to Conscious witness (puruṣa) is bondage-producing error.

25. Pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) maintains that:

A. The effect pre-exists latently in its material cause and becomes manifest B. All change is illusory C. The effect is wholly new D. Only efficient causes matter

Answer: A. The effect pre-exists latently in its material cause and becomes manifest

Explanation: Pre-existence is latent and determinate, not visible or spatial presence of the gross effect.

26. Asadakaraṇāt means:

A. Only atoms are eternal B. What is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced C. Every cause is conscious D. Effect wholly differs from cause

Answer: B. What is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced

Explanation: Production cannot turn sheer non-being into being; it manifests a determinate grounded effect.

27. Upādāna-grahaṇāt emphasises:

A. Identity of Conscious witness (puruṣa) and Primordial material nature (prakṛti) B. Need for a creator C. Selection of a specific material cause for a specific effect D. Unreality of matter

Answer: C. Selection of a specific material cause for a specific effect

Explanation: One selects milk for curd and mango seed for mango tree; specificity supports latent determination.

28. Sarvasambhavābhāvāt denies that:

A. Effects have names B. Causes possess powers C. Transformation is real D. Everything can arise from everything

Answer: D. Everything can arise from everything

Explanation: Sheer prior non-being cannot explain why only certain causes yield certain effects.

29. Śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt argues from:

A. A cause producing only what lies within its determinate capacity B. Destruction of prior absence C. Scriptural command D. Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s will

Answer: A. A cause producing only what lies within its determinate capacity

Explanation: A specific potency is directed toward a specific producible effect; Sāṃkhya reads this as latent grounding.

30. Kāraṇa-bhāvāt claims that:

A. Causation requires God B. The effect retains the material nature of its cause C. Cause and effect are unrelated D. Only form persists

Answer: B. The effect retains the material nature of its cause

Explanation: Gold remains through ornaments and threads through cloth; new arrangement is not new substance from nothing.

31. Sāṃkhya real transformation (pariṇāmavāda) differs from Advaita vivartavāda because:

A. Advaita accepts many Prakṛtis B. Sāṃkhya makes Brahman the material cause C. Sāṃkhya affirms real material transformation; Advaita, apparent transformation D. Both deny any world

Answer: C. Sāṃkhya affirms real material transformation; Advaita, apparent transformation

Explanation: Both deny creation from nothing, but differ decisively over real evolution versus appearance.

32. Nyāya non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda) holds that before production the effect:

A. Exists grossly inside cause B. Is Brahman C. Is concealed D. Is absent as effect (prāgabdhāva) and begins as a new product

Answer: D. Is absent as effect (prāgabdhāva) and begins as a new product

Explanation: Nyāya explains specificity through causal powers and conditions, not latent effect-pre-existence.

33. In the mango-seed example, the safest Sāṃkhya formulation is:

A. The seed contains mango-specific latent potency that really transforms under suitable conditions B. Soil alone is the material cause C. A miniature gross tree is spatially hidden in the seed D. Conscious witness (puruṣa) actively designs the tree

Answer: A. The seed contains mango-specific latent potency that really transforms under suitable conditions

Explanation: The seed is the determinate material continuum; soil, water and heat are auxiliaries. Pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) is not miniature-object identity.

34. Which criticism says pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) merely redescribes causal capacity as pre-existence?

A. The Yoga objection B. The Nyāya objection C. Buddhist two-truths theory D. Mīmāṃsā testimony theory

Answer: B. The Nyāya objection

Explanation: Nyāya grants determinate powers while denying that the effect exists before production.

35. Bondage in Sāṃkhya is fundamentally:

A. Primordial material nature (prakṛti)'s existence itself B. Divine punishment C. Aviveka and abhimāna-non-discrimination and false appropriation D. A real mutation of Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Answer: C. Aviveka and abhimāna-non-discrimination and false appropriation

Explanation: Determinative intellect (buddhi) acts and reflects consciousness; ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) appropriates. Conscious witness (puruṣa) remains unchanged.

36. Isolation (kaivalya) is attained through:

A. Ritual creation of a new self B. Union of Conscious witness (puruṣa) and Primordial material nature (prakṛti) C. Destruction of all Conscious witness (puruṣas) D. Stable discriminative knowledge (viveka-jñāna) distinguishing Conscious witness (puruṣa) from every guṇic process

Answer: D. Stable discriminative knowledge (viveka-jñāna) distinguishing Conscious witness (puruṣa) from every guṇic process

Explanation: Isolation (kaivalya) is isolation, not union with Brahman or God and not annihilation of Primordial material nature (prakṛti).

37. Which formulation distinguishes jīvanmukti and videhamukti in Sāṃkhya?

A. Discrimination may arise while bodily momentum continues; disembodiment follows when it ends B. Jīvanmukti means becoming God C. Videhamukti destroys Primordial material nature (prakṛti) universally D. Sāṃkhya rejects bodily continuation after knowledge

Answer: A. Discrimination may arise while bodily momentum continues; disembodiment follows when it ends

Explanation: The potter's-wheel analogy explains residual embodiment; the liberated witness does not become an agent.

38. Classical Sāṃkhya is called nirīśvara because:

A. It rejects inference B. Its world-process and liberation do not require a creator God C. It denies consciousness D. It identifies Conscious witness (puruṣa) with Lord (Īśvara)

Answer: B. Its world-process and liberation do not require a creator God

Explanation: Primordial material nature (prakṛti), plural Conscious witness (puruṣas) and discrimination are sufficient, distinguishing Sāṃkhya from theistic Yoga.

39. What is the contact problem?

A. How gross elements touch B. How testimony reaches Veda C. How universals are perceived D. How inactive Conscious witness (puruṣa) and unconscious Primordial material nature (prakṛti) can coordinate at all

Answer: C. How universals are perceived

Explanation: Evolution, experience and bondage require coordination, yet neither principle can initiate intentional relation.

40. What does the lame-blind analogy intend to show?

A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) as efficient cause B. Complementarity: consciousness without action and action without consciousness C. Identity of Conscious witness (puruṣa) and Primordial material nature (prakṛti) D. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) sees its goal

Answer: D. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) sees its goal

Explanation: It illustrates supplementation, but actual lame-blind cooperation presupposes communication and intention.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

Questions 41-48 target recurring conceptual and directive errors while continuing B → C → A → D.

41. Why does Śaṃkara reject the magnet-iron analogy as a complete solution?

A. It proves too many Conscious witness (puruṣas) B. A magnet exerts causal force, whereas Conscious witness (puruṣa) is wholly inactive C. It denies continuity D. Iron is conscious

Answer: A. It proves too many Conscious witness (puruṣas)

Explanation: The analogy imports efficacy that strict Puruṣa-inactivity excludes.

42. If proximity is a real relation, Śaṃkara argues that:

A. Only Primordial material nature (prakṛti) changes B. Liberation follows automatically C. Relation equals testimony D. Relational modification threatens independence; if unreal, it explains nothing

Answer: B. Liberation follows automatically

Explanation: The dilemma targets the explanatory status of sānnidhya.

43. Why is Sāṃkhya a pradhāna-malla for Śaṃkara?

A. It is the strongest systematic rival centred on unmanifest material root (pradhāna), causation, self and liberation B. It alone accepts Upaniṣads C. It is identical with Advaita D. It denies material cause

Answer: C. It is identical with Advaita

Explanation: "Chief opponent" marks philosophical strength and proximity, not a casual insult.

44. Śaṅkara's scriptural-causal objection is that the world-ground must be:

- A. A gross element B. Conscious and knowing, not unconscious unmanifest material root (pradhāna) C. Many atomic selves D. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra)

Answer: D. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra)

Explanation: He reads Upaniṣadic causation passages as attributing knowledge and purposiveness to the source.

45. What is Sāṃkhya's best reply to unconscious-teleology criticism?

- A. Ordered functioning can arise from inherent guṇa-nature in Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s presence without planning B. World is illusion C. Conscious witness (puruṣa) secretly acts D. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is conscious

Answer: A. Ordered functioning can arise from inherent guṇa-nature in Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s presence without planning

Explanation: Milk-calf and natural-process analogies defend purposive functioning without a deliberating planner, though contested.

46. Which comparison is accurate?

- A. Both accept real transformation of the ultimate B. Sāṃkhya accepts real transformation (pariṇāmavāda); Advaita protects Brahman through vivarta C. Advaita accepts many Prakṛtis D. Sāṃkhya makes māyā sole cause

Answer: B. Sāṃkhya accepts real transformation (pariṇāmavāda); Advaita protects Brahman through vivarta

Explanation: Sāṃkhya prioritises real material continuity; Advaita preserves ultimate changelessness through appearance.

47. A question saying "critically examine" requires:

- A. Only objections B. A list without argument C. Doctrine -> named objection -> Sāṃkhya reply -> residual judgement D. Definition alone

Answer: C. Doctrine -> named objection -> Sāṃkhya reply -> residual judgement

Explanation: Directive fidelity demands exposition and assessment, not one-sided criticism.

48. Which statement is an exam trap rather than sound doctrine?

- A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) is inactive witness B. Rajas energises both branches C. Cosmic intellect (mahat) and determinative intellect (buddhi) are one constitutive principle (tattva) under two aspects D. Government officially adopted a 2026 national Sāṃkhya mental-health paradigm

Answer: D. Government officially adopted a 2026 national Sāṃkhya mental-health paradigm

Explanation: No authoritative source supports that policy claim; classical doctrine must not be modernised through fabrication.

REVIEW-PROMOTED SOURCE AND CONTINUITY MCQS

49. Which statement is historically safest about classical Sāṃkhya?

- A. Kapila belongs to the received founding lineage, while Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṃkhyakārikā is the earliest extant systematic classical text; later sūtra and commentarial layers must be distinguished. B. Every doctrine is preserved verbatim in an extant work written by Kapila. C. The Sāṃkhyakārikā is a modern Yoga manual centred on eight-limbed practice. D. Classical Sāṃkhya and later theistic Sāṃkhya are textually identical.

Answer: A. Kapila belongs to the received founding lineage, while Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṃkhyakārikā is the earliest extant systematic classical text; later sūtra and commentarial layers must be distinguished.

Explanation: Received lineage and extant textual evidence are not the same. Source control prevents later theistic material from being projected into the classical Kārikā.

50. What is the correct reading of the third proof for primordial material nature in Sāṃkhyakārikā 15?

- A. kāryataḥ pravṛtteḥ - conscious purpose creates effects. B. śaktiṭaḥ pravṛtteś ca - effects operate from the relevant causal power. C. saṅghāta-parārthatvāt - aggregates exist for another. D. kaivalyārthaṁ pravṛtteḥ - striving proves liberation.

Answer: B. śaktitaḥ pravṛtteś ca - effects operate from the relevant causal power.

Explanation: The argument is from productive potency, not conscious planning. Saṅghāta-parārthatvāt and kaivalyārthaṁ pravṛtteḥ belong to proofs for Conscious witness (puruṣa).

51. Which cause-effect classification of the twenty-five principles is correct?

A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) is cause only, and primordial nature is an effect. B. All twenty-five are simultaneous products of ego-maker. C. Primordial nature is cause only; intellect, ego and five subtle elements are cause-effects; eleven instruments and five gross elements are effects only; Conscious witness (puruṣa) is neither. D. The five gross elements are causes of primordial nature.

Answer: C. Primordial nature is cause only; intellect, ego and five subtle elements are cause-effects; eleven instruments and five gross elements are effects only; Conscious witness (puruṣa) is neither.

Explanation: The classification controls both count and evolutionary direction while keeping Conscious witness (puruṣa) outside material production.

52. What is the function of the subtle body in classical Sāṃkhya?

A. It is the eternal conscious witness that directly performs actions. B. It is the gross parental body that ends at every death without continuity. C. It is a creator God that allocates karmic fruits. D. It is the commonly eighteen-principle psychophysical vehicle carrying dispositions between gross embodiments, while pure Conscious witness (puruṣa) neither acts nor migrates.

Answer: D. It is the commonly eighteen-principle psychophysical vehicle carrying dispositions between gross embodiments, while pure Conscious witness (puruṣa) neither acts nor migrates.

Explanation: The subtle body links action and moral consequence (karma) and rebirth without compromising Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s inactivity, though critics may still press moral ownership.

53. Which set gives Sāṃkhya's threefold suffering?

A. Internal/psychophysical, other-being/material, and cosmic or unseen suffering. B. Past, present and future suffering. C. Sattva, rajas and tamas. D. Birth, action and liberation.

Answer: A. Internal/psychophysical, other-being/material, and cosmic or unseen suffering.

Explanation: These are internal (ādhyātmika), external-being/material (ādhibhautika) and cosmic/unseen (ādhidaivika) afflictions that motivate final discriminative release.

54. Which statement best captures the apparent-agency problem?

A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) produces the material world by deliberate volition. B. The internal instrument appears conscious through reflection, while inactive Conscious witness (puruṣa) appears to act; productive agency actually belongs to the qualities and evolutes of primordial nature. C. Primordial nature is conscious but refuses to act. D. Ego-maker is an eternal self outside evolution.

Answer: B. The internal instrument appears conscious through reflection, while inactive Conscious witness (puruṣa) appears to act; productive agency actually belongs to the qualities and evolutes of primordial nature.

Explanation: Conjunction produces a two-way misattribution. This explains empirical agency while protecting Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s changelessness.

55. Which statement about plurality of Conscious witness (puruṣas) is textually controlled?

A. Sāṃkhyakārikā 18 gives seven independent proofs. B. The only proof is the existence of a creator God. C. The Kārikā stresses fixed distributions of birth/death/faculties, non-simultaneous activity and constituent quality (guṇa) differences; differential liberation is a supplementary argument. D. Conscious witness (puruṣas) differ qualitatively in consciousness.

Answer: C. The Kārikā stresses fixed distributions of birth/death/faculties, non-simultaneous activity and constituent quality (guṇa) differences; differential liberation is a supplementary argument.

Explanation: Conscious witness (puruṣas) are numerically many but qualitatively alike. The source-controlled order prevents later supporting arguments from being mistaken for the verse's exact list.

56. Why is classical Sāṃkhya better called non-theistic or God-unproved?

A. It rejects Vedic testimony and every spiritual principle. B. It identifies Conscious witness (puruṣa) with an omnipotent creator. C. It makes Yoga's special Conscious witness (puruṣa) the twenty-sixth creator of primordial nature. D. It holds primordial nature and many conscious witnesses sufficient for world and liberation, while later Sāṃkhya may admit stronger theistic interpretation.

Answer: D. It holds primordial nature and many conscious witnesses sufficient for world and liberation, while later Sāṃkhya may admit stronger theistic interpretation.

Explanation: Classical Sāṃkhya does not need God for material evolution or release. This differs from Yoga, which owns the special-Puruṣa and practical-theistic framework.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 10 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Independent learner-practice models, not official UPSC answer keys. Wording, year, question number and marks follow the verified local PYQ corpus.

2018 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Question: Is Conscious witness (Puruṣa) one or many? Explain the Sāṃkhya position in this regard and give arguments in support of your answer.

Demand decoding

Fix Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s numerical status, derive plurality from empirical and soteriological differences, and test whether those differences really individuate pure consciousness.

Independent model answer

Samkhya accepts **many Conscious witness (puruṣas)**. Each Conscious witness (puruṣa) is eternal, inactive, attributeless pure consciousness, but numerical plurality is required to explain differences among embodied streams.

The standard arguments are:

1. **Separate births and deaths:** one organism begins or ends without all doing so.
2. **Non-simultaneous activity:** when one sleeps, another acts.
3. **Diversity of experience:** pleasure, pain and knowledge differ among persons.
4. **Moral individuality:** karmic fruits attach to distinct empirical streams.
5. **Non-simultaneous liberation:** one person's release does not liberate all.

Advaita objects that attributeless consciousness cannot be numerically differentiated; apparent plurality may arise from distinct adjuncts. Samkhya replies that if only one Conscious witness (puruṣa) existed, bondage and liberation would become universally simultaneous.

Verdict: Plurality protects moral and soteriological individuality, though the principle distinguishing qualitatively identical Conscious witness (puruṣas) remains under-explained.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2018 · Q5(e) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- States many numerically distinct but qualitatively alike Conscious witness (puruṣas).
- Uses birth/death, activity, experience, action and moral consequence (karma) and liberation as arguments.
- Adds the Advaita hidden limiting condition (upādhi) objection and simultaneity reply.
- Ends with a qualified judgement on individuation.

2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: How do the Advaita Vedāntins react to the Prakṛtipariṇāma-vāda of the Sāṃkhya philosophy? How do the Sāṃkhyas defend their own position in this regard? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Present Advaita's objections to real transformation by unconscious Primordial material nature (prakṛti), reconstruct Sāṃkhya's defence, and reach the balanced verdict required by "discuss".

Independent model answer

Samkhya holds that Primordial material nature (prakṛti) really transforms into the world. The effect pre-exists in the cause and becomes manifest through **parinama**. Advaita accepts pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) at a broad level but rejects independent unconscious Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and real transformation of ultimate reality.

Sankara's objections are:

1. An unconscious unmanifest material root (pradhāna) cannot initiate purposive, ordered evolution.
2. If Conscious witness (puruṣa) is inactive and Primordial material nature (prakṛti) independent, their relation is unintelligible.
3. The Upanisads present an intelligent principle, not unconscious matter, as world-ground.
4. Real transformation would compromise the changelessness of ultimate reality.
5. Two independent absolutes leave their coordination unexplained.

Advaita therefore proposes **vivartavada**: the world is an appearance of Brahman through maya, not a real transformation of Brahman.

Samkhya replies that effects share the guna-structure of their cause and require material continuity. Milk changes into curd without an external intelligent planner; similarly Primordial material nature (prakṛti)'s inherent tendency and Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s proximity suffice. A God does not explain how consciousness creates unconscious matter, whereas Primordial material nature (prakṛti) naturally contains the material potency of the world.

Verdict: Samkhya explains real causal continuity better; Advaita presses the deeper problem of how unconscious teleology and dual coordination are possible.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Defines pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) and real transformation (pariṇāma-vāda) before comparison.
- Organises objections around causation, teleology, scripture and relation.
- Gives replies from material continuity and inherent guṇa-potency.
- Distinguishes real transformation (pariṇāma-vāda) from vivarta and balances both sides.

2019 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: Critically discuss the metaphysical status of a Individual self (jīva) and a Conscious witness (Puruṣa) according to Sāṃkhya philosophy.

Demand decoding

Distinguish the unconditioned witness from the empirical self, explain reflection and appropriation, and address the paradox of bondage without change in Conscious witness (puruṣa).

Independent model answer

Conscious witness (puruṣa) is pure, eternal, inactive consciousness-witness, not agent or product. **Individual self (jīva)** is Conscious witness (puruṣa) apparently associated with the subtle body, determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṁkāra), sensory mind (manas), senses and karmic dispositions.

Conscious witness (puruṣa)	Individual self (jīva)
pure consciousness	empirical embodied subject
inactive witness	appears as knower, doer, enjoyer
unbound in itself	subject to bondage and transmigration
plural and eternal	psychophysical stream around one Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Determinative intellect (buddhi) is material but sattva-predominant and reflects consciousness. Ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) appropriates this reflected awareness as "I know" and "I act." Bondage belongs strictly to Primordial material nature (prakṛti)'s apparatus, yet is attributed to Conscious witness (puruṣa) through non-discrimination.

The criticism is severe: if Conscious witness (puruṣa) is never really bound, liberation appears unnecessary; if Individual self (jīva) alone is bound, it is unclear who seeks release. Samkhya replies that liberation removes false identification, not a real modification of Conscious witness (puruṣa).

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2019 · Q5(d) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Separates Conscious witness (puruṣa) from individual self (jīva) and denies that individual self (jīva) is another constitutive principle (tattva).
- Explains buddhi-reflection and ego-maker (ahaṁkāra)'s appropriation.
- Handles bondage without making Conscious witness (puruṣa) an agent.
- Raises and answers the liberation paradox.

2019 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Which Sāṃkhya proof for the existence of Primordial material nature (prakṛti) actually shows that there can be only one Primordial material nature (prakṛti)? Justify your answer.

Demand decoding

Identify the proof supporting numerical unity, distinguish it from the other existence-proofs, justify its inference, and state its limitation.

Independent model answer

The decisive proof is **avibhagat vaisvarūpyasya**: the differentiated universe points to an undivided source. The cosmos displays immense plurality but also systemic unity and reciprocal transformation. Its differentiated forms must emerge from one unmanifest matrix in which they are not yet divided.

The other proofs establish the need for a material ground:

- *bhedanam parimanat*: finite effects require a ground.
- *samanvayat*: common guna-structure suggests a common cause.
- *karyatah pravṛtteh*: productive activity presupposes potency.
- *karana-karya-vibhagat*: manifest effect differs from unmanifest causal state.

These support Primordial material nature (prakṛti)'s existence, but they do not as directly exclude multiple root causes. The fifth proof specifically moves from unified diversification to one undivided source.

An opponent may argue that cosmic coordination does not logically prove numerical unity; several coordinated causes are possible. Samkhya replies that multiple Prakritis with the same guna-constitution are explanatorily redundant and would require a higher principle coordinating them.

Verdict: The proof is abductive rather than demonstrative: one Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is the most economical common material explanation of an interconnected guna-world.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2019 · Q8(c) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Names avibhāgāt vaiśvarūpyasya precisely.
- Shows why the other proofs do not establish unity as directly.
- Bridges coordinated diversity to an undivided source.
- Qualifies the inference as abductive, not demonstrative.

2020 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question: “A mango tree is grown out of a mango seed.” How will Sāṃkhya system explain this process through their theory of causation by rejecting their rival perspectives?

Demand decoding

Apply all five pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) arguments to seed-tree causation, explain real transformation (pariṇāmavāda), reject rivals, and avoid the miniature-tree fallacy.

Independent model answer

Samkhya explains the mango tree through **pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda)**: the effect exists latently in its material cause before manifestation. The seed is not an actual miniature tree, but it contains the determinate material potency that can unfold into that tree under suitable conditions.

Five arguments support the doctrine:

1. **Asadakaranat:** what is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced.
2. **Upadana-grahanat:** production requires a specific material cause.
3. **Sarvasambhavabhavat:** everything cannot arise from everything.
4. **Saktasya sakya-karanat:** a cause produces only what lies within its capacity.
5. **Karana-bhavat:** effect retains the nature of the cause.

The seed-to-tree process is **real transformation (pariṇāmavāda)**, real transformation. Production is manifestation; destruction is return to an unmanifest condition. Soil, water and heat are auxiliaries, while the seed carries mango-specific causal power.

Nyaya's non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda) says the tree is newly produced and had prior absence. Samkhya objects that if wholly absent, its production from this rather than any cause is unintelligible. Nyaya replies that capacity, not latent effect, limits production.

Buddhist dependent origination treats seed and tree as momentary causal series without enduring material identity. Samkhya argues that a shared substrate and continuity better explain determinate transformation.

Advaita vivartavada treats worldly transformation as appearance relative to Brahman. Samkhya insists the empirical world and its changes are real and require real material evolution.

Verdict: Pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) powerfully explains specificity and continuity, though critics may say it redescribes capacity as pre-existence and weakens genuine novelty.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2020 · Q7(a) · 20 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Applies all five causal arguments to mango-specific production.
- Separates the material seed from auxiliary conditions.
- Rejects the gross miniature-tree reading.
- Engages Nyāya, Buddhist and Advaita alternatives.

2021 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the Sāṃkhya view on three qualities (guṇas) (guṇa-traya) and their modifications.

Demand decoding

Define the three constitutive qualities (guṇas), explain equilibrium and both modifications, and connect their interplay to cosmology and psychology.

Independent model answer

Primordial material nature (prakṛti) consists of **sattva, rajas and tamas**, not as qualities added to a substance but as its constitutive strands.

Constituent quality (guṇa)	Character	Psychological expression	Physical tendency
Sattva	illumination, lightness	clarity, pleasure, knowledge	upward/light
Rajas	activity, stimulation	desire, effort, restlessness	motion
Tamas	restraint, heaviness	ignorance, dullness, obstruction	inertia/downward

They are mutually opposed yet cooperative, like oil, wick and flame. Every product contains all three in different proportions.

In primordial Primordial material nature (prakṛti) they undergo **sarupa-parinama**, homogeneous internal change that preserves equilibrium. Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s proximity disturbs balance and produces **virupa-parinama**, heterogeneous predominance initiating evolution. Rajas activates; sattva and tamas differentiate into cognitive and material lines.

Modification never creates substance from nothing. Each constitutive principle (tattva) is a new configuration of the same guna-material. This grounds both cosmology and psychology: knowledge, desire, inertia, senses and elements are stages of one material evolution.

Verdict: Constituent quality (guṇa) theory unifies mind and matter without reducing one to the other, but it risks explaining diverse phenomena through highly elastic principles.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2021 · Q6(b) · 15 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Treats qualities (guṇas) as constituents, not detachable qualities.
- Explains cooperation, equilibrium and disequilibrium.
- Distinguishes sarūpa from virūpa real transformation (pariṇā mavāda).
- Connects modification to psychology and evolution.

2022 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: Examine and evaluate the proofs given by Sāṃkhya philosophy to prove the existence of Conscious witness (Puruṣa).

Demand decoding

Explain all five proofs and evaluate whether they establish a subject-pole, an eternal Conscious witness (puruṣa) and plurality with equal success.

Independent model answer

Samkhya gives five cumulative proofs:

1. **Sanghata-pararthatvat:** aggregates exist for another; body-mind serves a conscious subject.
2. **Trigunadi-viparyayat:** the witness must be opposite to the changing, unconscious qualities (guṇas).
3. **Adhithanat:** organized experience requires a presiding consciousness.
4. **Bhoktr-bhavat:** pleasure and pain require an experiencer.
5. **Kaivalyartham pravrtteh:** striving for liberation presupposes a liberable witness.

The arguments jointly distinguish the objectifiable psychophysical apparatus from a non-objective subject. They are strongest phenomenologically: experience seems to require a standpoint not reducible to what is experienced.

Buddhists deny that aggregates exist "for" a separate owner and explain experience as a causal stream. Advaita accepts witness-consciousness but denies its plurality.

Verdict: The proofs establish a subject-pole more plausibly than they establish many eternal, wholly inactive Conscious witness (puruṣas). Their cumulative force exceeds each argument taken alone.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2022 · Q5(a) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Presents all five technical proofs accurately.
- Explains their cumulative phenomenological logic.
- Separates witness-proof from proof of plural eternal witnesses.
- Uses Buddhist and Advaita objections evaluatively.

2023 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: "If Conscious witness (Puruṣa) and Primordial material nature (prakṛti) are two completely independent realities, then no relation between the two is possible." In the light of this statement make a brief presentation of Śaṅkara's criticism of Sāṃkhya dualism.

Demand decoding

Reconstruct Śaṅkara's relation-dilemma, test Sāṃkhya's proximity analogies, and judge whether dualist coordination is intelligible.

Independent model answer

Sankara argues that Samkhya's two independent principles cannot initiate a coordinated world-process. Conscious witness (puruṣa) is inactive and changeless; Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is unconscious. Neither can intentionally approach, affect or know the other.

If proximity is a real relation, both principles undergo relational modification and lose absolute independence. If proximity is unreal, it cannot explain the disturbance of guna-equilibrium. If it is beginningless, evolution should be continuous and liberation impossible.

The lame-and-blind analogy assumes cooperation but does not explain its ground: the lame person consciously directs the blind, whereas Conscious witness (puruṣa) cannot act and Primordial material nature (prakṛti) cannot understand.

Samkhya replies that proximity is not physical contact but reflective presence. A magnet moves iron without changing itself, and Primordial material nature (prakṛti) operates for Conscious witness (puruṣa) like milk flowing for the calf.

Verdict: The analogies clarify non-mechanical influence but do not fully explain how two independent absolutes enter a purposive relation.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2023 · Q5(b) · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Answers the quoted impossibility claim directly.
- Develops the real/unreal/beginningless relation dilemma.
- Tests lame-blind, magnet-iron and milk-calf analogies.
- Concludes on coordination without agency.

2024 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question: Present an account of evolution of Primordial material nature (prakṛti) as propounded in Sāṃkhyakārikā. In this context, also explain the difference between determinative intellect (buddhi), cosmic intellect (mahat) and ego-maker (ahaṃkāra).

Demand decoding

Give the exact evolutionary sequence and count, then distinguish cosmic intellect (mahat)/determinative intellect (buddhi) from ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) without making cosmic intellect (mahat) and determinative intellect (buddhi) separate principles (tattvas).

Independent model answer

Evolution begins when the equilibrium of sattva, rajas and tamas in unmanifest nature (avyakta) Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is disturbed in the presence of Conscious witness (puruṣa).

Primordial material nature (prakṛti)

↓

Cosmic intellect (mahat) / Determinative intellect (buddhi)

↓

Ego-maker (ahaṃkāra)

- + - sattvika line -> sensory mind (manas) + 5 cognitive senses + 5 action senses
- + - tamasa line -> 5 subtle element (tanmātras) -> 5 gross elements
- + - rajas -> energizes both lines

Together with Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and Conscious witness (puruṣa), the evolutes form twenty-five principles (tattvas).

Cosmic intellect (mahat) is the first cosmic evolute-the "great" principle of determination in the universal process.

Determinative intellect (buddhi) is the same constitutive principle (tattva) viewed psychologically as individual determinative intellect; it performs adhyavasaya, judgement and discrimination. Thus cosmic intellect (mahat) and determinative intellect (buddhi) are not two separate principles (tattvas).

Ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) is the next evolute, the I-maker that appropriates experience as "I" and "mine." From its sattvika aspect arise the eleven faculties; from its tamasa aspect arise five subtle elements. Rajas supplies activity.

Determinative intellect (buddhi) is material, not consciousness. Its sattva-like transparency reflects Conscious witness (puruṣa), creating the appearance of a conscious intellect. Ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) misappropriates reflected consciousness and generates bondage.

Critics question how mere proximity initiates evolution and how unconscious Primordial material nature (prakṛti) acts purposively. Samkhya replies that transformation is inherent in the qualities (guṇas) and serves the dual ends of experience and liberation.

Verdict: The scheme unifies cosmology and psychology with remarkable economy, though its first transition from independent Conscious witness (puruṣa) to disturbed Primordial material nature (prakṛti) remains the weakest link.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2024 · Q7(a) · 20 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Gives the exact sequence and both evolutionary branches.
- Counts twenty-five principles (tattvas) without making Conscious witness (puruṣa) an evolute.
- Distinguishes determination from I-appropriation.
- Adds contact and teleology evaluation.

2025 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question: Why does Śaṅkara consider Sāṃkhya Philosophy as his chief opponent (pradhāna malla)? Examine his arguments against Sāṃkhya Philosophy.

Demand decoding

Explain why Sāṃkhya is Advaita's strongest rival, then examine Śaṅkara's scriptural, causal, teleological, relational and soteriological objections.

Independent model answer

Samkhya is Advaita's chief opponent because it offers the strongest systematic rival account of one world-ground, causation, bondage and liberation. Both seek an ultimate explanation beneath plurality and accept that ignorance causes bondage, but Samkhya proposes unconscious Unmanifest material root (pradhāna) and many Conscious witness (puruṣas) where Advaita proposes non-dual Brahman.

Sankara's principal criticisms are:

1. **Scriptural:** Upanisadic causation passages describe an intelligent knowing source, not unconscious Unmanifest material root (pradhāna).
2. **Teleological:** unconscious Primordial material nature (prakṛti) cannot produce an ordered world for experience and liberation.
3. **Contact problem:** inactive Conscious witness (puruṣa) and independent Primordial material nature (prakṛti) cannot enter an intelligible relation.
4. **Analogy failure:** milk-calf and lame-blind examples presuppose structures absent from the two principles.
5. **Plurality problem:** qualitatively identical, attributeless Conscious witness (puruṣas) lack a differentiating principle.
6. **Causal criticism:** real transformation of the ultimate threatens its independence; Advaita prefers apparent transformation.
7. **Bondage paradox:** an eternally inactive witness cannot really be bound or liberated.

Samkhya replies that material continuity requires Primordial material nature (prakṛti); the qualities (guṇas) explain mind and matter; plurality protects individual action and moral consequence (karma); and intelligence need not plan natural transformation. Advaita, in turn, must explain how maya and appearance arise without compromising Brahman.

Sankara treats Samkhya seriously because it cannot be dismissed as crude materialism. It shares renunciatory and discriminative aims, supplies a mature causal theory, and deeply influenced the conceptual vocabulary of Indian thought.

Verdict: Sankara's strongest objection is not mere scriptural disagreement but explanatory coordination: Sāṃkhya cannot fully show how an unconscious independent cause evolves for an inactive independent consciousness. Yet Advaita replaces this with its own māyā problem.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in 2025 · Q7(a) · 20 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Explains pradhāna-malla as strength and proximity.
- Covers scriptural, teleological, relational, plurality and bondage objections.
- Includes material-continuity and nirīśvara replies.
- Compares Sāṃkhya's gap with Advaita's māyā problem.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

These six questions are original practice, not PYQs. Models are independent learner answers.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Why is Sāṃkhya epistemology indispensable to its metaphysics?

Demand decoding

Link the three-pramāṇa scheme to imperceptible principles; explain sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa and evaluate its reach.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya metaphysics depends on epistemology because its two ultimate realities are not ordinary objects of perception. It admits only **perception (pratyakṣa)**, **inference (anumāna)** and **āptavacana/verbal testimony (śabda)**. Root Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is imperceptible through subtlety, while Conscious witness (puruṣa) is the non-objective witness; neither can simply be introduced as a perceptual datum.

The decisive bridge is **sāmānyato-dṛṣṭa inference (anumāna)**. From finite, coordinated and guṇa-structured effects, Sāṃkhya infers one unmanifest material ground. From objectifiable aggregates, experienced pleasure and pain, and striving for release, it infers consciousness distinct from the qualities (guṇas). Testimony can confirm these conclusions, but inference permits argument without presupposing scripture.

This economy gives methodological unity: unseen entities answer defined explanatory needs. Yet it is underdetermined. Cārvāka doubts inference to a never-perceived term; Nyāya accepts inference but proposes atoms, selves and Lord (Īśvara). Thus Sāṃkhya metaphysics is an inferential construction whose force depends on whether general correlation warrants these particular unseen principles.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 1* · 10 marks, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.
- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish material cause, auxiliary conditions and conscious witness in Sāṃkhya causation.

Demand decoding

Identify material continuity, enabling conditions and Conscious witness (puruṣa) as a non-agentive witness through the mango-seed example.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya explains production through an **upādāna-kāraṇa**, a material cause that really transforms. In the mango case, the seed bears determinate mango-producing potency; soil, water, heat and cultivation are enabling conditions. The gross tree is not spatially hidden in the seed, but its determinate effect-form is latent in that material continuum.

Conscious witness (puruṣa) is neither material cause nor productive agent. It is pure inactive consciousness. Its presence makes the process experienced, while every transformation belongs to Primordial material nature (prakṛti) and the qualities (guṇas). This preserves pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda): an effect arises from an appropriate material basis, not sheer non-being. It also preserves real transformation (pariṇāmavāda): the substrate undergoes real reconfiguration.

Calling Conscious witness (puruṣa) the designer would import Nyāya or theistic Yoga; calling auxiliaries the sole material cause would destroy causal continuity. Sāṃkhya gains a precise naturalistic account of transformation, though Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s non-causal presence reopens the contact problem.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 2 · 10 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.
- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Does constituent quality (guṇa) theory successfully unify Sāṃkhya cosmology and psychology? Evaluate.

Demand decoding

Explain the three qualities (guṇas), both modifications and their work in evolution and cognition; weigh integration against elasticity.

Model answer

The qualities (guṇas) are constitutive strands of Primordial material nature (prakṛti). **Sattva** illuminates and is associated with clarity and pleasure; **rajas** activates and is associated with effort and pain; **tamas** restrains and obscures, producing heaviness and delusion. Their equilibrium is unmanifest nature (avyakta) Primordial material nature (prakṛti). **Sarūpa-pariṇāma** is homogeneous change compatible with equilibrium; **virūpa-pariṇāma** begins with unequal predominance and generates differentiated principles (tattvas).

Cosmologically, constituent quality (guṇa) transformation explains the sequence from cosmic intellect (mahat)/determinative intellect (buddhi) and ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) to faculties, subtle element (tanmātras) and gross elements. Rajas energises both the sāttvika cognitive line and tāmasa material line. Psychologically, sattva makes determinative intellect (buddhi) transparent to reflected consciousness, rajas drives action, and tamas obstructs discrimination. Mind and matter are continuous products of one material principle.

This is a major achievement: one triadic grammar connects physical density, affect, cognition and temperament. Yet its breadth is also a weakness. Almost any event can be redescribed as a guṇa-mixture, with limited independent criteria for measuring proportions. Further, it explains structured change after disequilibrium better than why inactive Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s proximity occasions it.

Constituent quality (guṇa) theory therefore integrates Sāṃkhya's architecture more strongly than it independently proves its ontology.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 3 · 15 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

- Opens with a thesis tailored to the directive and marks.
- Uses named Sāṃkhya concepts and an exact doctrinal distinction.
- Builds claim, evidence/example and analysis rather than listing labels.
- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Is Sāṃkhya's doctrine of many Conscious witness (puruṣas) philosophically necessary? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Present plurality arguments, distinguish empirical streams from witnesses, include Advaita's individuation objection, and give a qualified verdict.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya requires many Conscious witness (puruṣas) to preserve the non-transferability of embodied life. Birth and death occur separately; sense-capacities differ; one person acts while another sleeps; pleasure, pain and karmic consequences are not universally shared; and one person's discrimination does not liberate everyone. A single Conscious witness (puruṣa) would make bondage and release simultaneous and universal.

Plurality protects moral and soteriological individuality while keeping consciousness free from guṇic difference. Conscious witness (puruṣas) are numerically many but qualitatively alike: each pure, changeless and inactive. Distinct subtle bodies carry dispositions and provide different loci in which consciousness is reflected.

Advaita objects that all cited differences belong to bodies and minds, not attributeless consciousness. Sāṃkhya may prove many cittas or individual self (jīvas) without proving many Conscious witness (puruṣas). Nyāya, though pluralist, adds that an inactive witness poorly bears moral responsibility. Sāṃkhya replies that making Conscious witness (puruṣa) an agent would turn bondage into a real modification; empirical agency must remain in determinative intellect (buddhi) and ego-maker (ahaṃkāra).

Plurality is systemically necessary for Sāṃkhya's realism and individual liberation. Philosophically, however, its evidence establishes distinct psychophysical streams more clearly than an ultimate individuator among qualitatively identical witnesses.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 4 · 15 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

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Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: “Sāṃkhya secures causal continuity at the cost of genuine novelty.” Critically examine pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) and real transformation (pariṇāmavāda).

Demand decoding

Derive the five arguments, explain real transformation, answer novelty and rivals, and judge whether latent effect exceeds causal capacity.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya's **pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda)** holds that an effect pre-exists latently in its material cause; production is manifestation, not creation from sheer non-being. Its form is **real transformation (pariṇāmavāda)**, because the material cause really transforms. The doctrine explains why production is continuous, determinate and intelligible.

Five arguments support it. **Asadakaraṇāt:** what is absolutely non-existent cannot be produced. **Upādāna-grahaṇāt:** a specific effect requires a specific material cause. **Sarvasambhavābhāvāt:** everything does not arise from everything. **Śaktasya śakya-karaṇāt:** a cause produces only what lies within its capacity. **Kāraṇa-bhāvāt:** the effect retains the material being of its cause, as cloth retains threads or an ornament gold. A mango tree therefore emerges from mango-specific potency in the seed under auxiliary conditions; no gross miniature tree is hidden there.

The novelty charge is partly justified. If effect and cause were simply identical, causal effort would be redundant. Sāṃkhya answers through **avasthā-bheda:** latent and manifest states differ, while new organisation and properties are real modifications of an enduring continuum. Novelty is configurational, not creation ex nihilo.

Nyāya gives the effect prior absence and treats it as a new whole. It explains specificity through causal power without identifying power with latent effect. Sāṃkhya replies that a power determinately for X already grounds X in the cause; otherwise restriction is named, not explained. Advaita denies creation from non-being but replaces real transformation of the ultimate with vivarta. Sāṃkhya objects that appearance explains empirical material continuity less directly.

Pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) secures continuity and specificity by restricting novelty to manifestation and transformation. Its unresolved issue is whether latent effect explains causal capacity or merely redescribes it; nevertheless it remains a coherent alternative to both new production and merely apparent change.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 5 · 20 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

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Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: “The purity of Conscious witness (puruṣa) and the activity of Primordial material nature (prakṛti) make liberation intelligible but their conjunction unintelligible.” Examine.

Demand decoding

Integrate reflection, individual self (jīva), bondage, viveka, isolation (kaivalya), analogies, Śaṅkara's dilemma and Sāṃkhya replies; evaluate the trade-off.

Model answer

Sāṃkhya assigns consciousness and activity to different principles. Conscious witness (puruṣa) is pure, changeless and inactive witness; Primordial material nature (prakṛti) is unconscious but productive. This makes liberation intelligible: if consciousness itself changed and suffered, release could not be stable. Bondage can instead be **aviveka**, false identification with material processes, and liberation **discriminative knowledge (viveka-jñāna)**, recognition that every change belongs to Primordial material nature (prakṛti).

Empirical life is explained through reflection. Sattva-predominant determinative intellect (buddhi), though insentient, reflects Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s consciousness; ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) appropriates cognition and action as "I know" and "I do." Individual self (jīva) is Conscious witness (puruṣa) appearing through this subtle-body complex, not another constitutive principle (tattva). When discrimination becomes firm, Primordial material nature (prakṛti)'s binding display ceases for that Conscious witness (puruṣa). Bodily momentum may continue like a potter's wheel (jīvanmukti) until videhamukti. Isolation (kaivalya) is isolation, not union with God; classical Sāṃkhya is nirīśvara.

The separation creates the contact problem. If the principles are independent, what disturbs guṇa-equilibrium, produces reflection or directs evolution toward experience and release? Sāṃkhya invokes **sānnidhya**, mere proximity. Lame-blind depicts complementary capacities; magnet-iron depicts activation without deliberation; crystal-flower depicts apparent colouring; dancer-spectator depicts withdrawal after disclosure.

Śaṅkara argues that these images borrow what the theory denies. The lame directs the blind intentionally; a magnet exerts force; crystal-flower explains appearance but not cosmic initiation. If proximity is real, independence and changelessness are qualified; if unreal, it explains nothing; if invariant and beginningless, manifestation should not cease. Unconscious unmanifest material root (pradhāna) also seems unable to organise a world "for" another.

Sāṃkhya replies that natural purposiveness need not be conscious planning: milk nourishes a calf without deliberation, and qualities (guṇas) have inherent transformative tendencies. Adding Lord (Īśvara) does not explain material continuity. It may also charge Advaita with replacing coordination by the difficult relation of Brahman, māyā and appearance.

The quotation is substantially correct. The purity/activity division gives a powerful non-reductive account of consciousness and liberation, but reflected experience and purposive coordination remain Sāṃkhya's deepest metaphysical gap.

Why this earns marks

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Original 6 · 20 marks*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

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- Includes an objection or limitation and a Sāṃkhya response.
- Ends with a qualified philosophical judgement.